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Case Study: Project Cornerstone

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Introduction

East Side High School is a large school located in an urban area of Santa Clara County. The school serves a complex community with the following characteristics: high levels of poverty, higher crime rates, diverse ethnic populations, and lower academic standards for students who receive developmental assets. There is also a significant cohort of Aboriginal students, and the school acts as a secondary annex for all public schools in the area. In addition, the proportion of students with developmental assets is lower than the city average. Developmental assets are the positive relationships, opportunities, values, and skills that students need to grow into caring, responsible adults (e.g., Family Support, Community Values Children and Youth, Self-Esteem).

The principal and staff of East Side High School recognize the critical importance of implementing more holistic approaches to student development and closely monitoring the academic performance of all students through detailed data collection and record-keeping. The academic performance of students with developmental disabilities has been a particular focus of the school's work. For this reason, East Side partners with community organizations in the local area to increase graduation rates, improve learning outcomes, and ultimately increase students' levels of developmental assets.

The intent of Project Cornerstone is to build a web of support around every young person in our community. Principal parties of this web of support include students, school staff, school administrators, families, community centers, faith communities, and local businesses. Consequently, these resources are disconnected from each other and often from students as well. Project Cornerstone facilitates the connection of the separate

parts of the web so that students can count on individuals and organizations working together to provide them with consistent support and guidance.

For the principal, John Smith, good relationships among schools, city government, foundations, businesses, faith communities, and other community groups, and between staff and students, are the heart of students' success at East Side. This success is fostered by improving students' experiences as they grow up in an environment with community-based partnerships. The results of this success are provided by report cards and indicate how the communities support the healthy development of students and youth. Mr. Smith hired a consultant from the YMCA of Santa Clara County to train staff on how to effect change in communities by building strengths and assets and creating reciprocal partnerships and social cohesion. He places great importance on the staff's ability to connect students with positive adults who can offer support and encouragement. With the staff's input, he created an after-school community outreach program to encourage students to speak up, get involved in public policy, and contribute their ideas and energy to help others within the community.

The intent of Project Cornerstone is to promote the research-based developmental assets approach as a guiding framework and a common language, enabling individual students and organizations to work together toward our shared goal of supporting the healthy development of all students and youth. Project Cornerstone encourages students to join community clubs, sports, and other activities. This process helps connect students with positive adults who offer support and encouragement. This is also important for students, especially during adolescence, when it is normal and healthy for students to become increasingly independent from their parents and families.

The impact of Project Cornerstone on students was that they had to attend a seminar to learn the fundamentals of building assets. In addition, they were asked to participate in at least one club, group, team, or sport and encouraged to build assets with their friends and neighbors. They also attended a conflict-mediation course and participated in “Getting to Know Your Teacher Day” to help them connect with the staff.

East Side is mandated by the school board to improve student test scores and academic performance. Furthermore, the city and its entire community have a vested interest in developmental assets for young people. This program outlines actions and responsibilities to help schools implement Project Cornerstone. The successful implementation of Project Cornerstone means lower crime rates among students, helping them become productive, contributing members of the community and society. However, this voluntary program is a cooperative effort of the City of San Jose, community groups, businesses, and schools to help students develop their developmental assets.

Analysis

This case study details how the school used Project Cornerstone to improve students' learning outcomes and behaviors. Project Cornerstone described developmental assets as a social change movement for student and school climate. It aimed to help students and address their developmental needs, thereby promoting positive behavior, academic success, and school safety. These actions were also linked to promoting the quality of the school environment. The Search Institute (1989), a well-known nonprofit organization, published a framework called “40 Developmental Assets”. The Search Institute's 40 developmental assets are concrete, common sense, positive experiences and qualities essential to raising successful young people.

The principal, John Smith, at East Side High School used Project Cornerstone to figure out what was going wrong within the community by implementing the student survey. Looking at the survey, Mr. Smith was able to identify the areas where students needed help. Based on the survey, students were rebellious. They wanted their own space and liked to hang out with their friends, not parents. In addition, they liked to associate with young people at the mall and create trouble.

The key elements for success in Project Cornerstone were community groups, city governments and local community leaders. Working with community groups (YMCA, Girl Scouts, Boy Scouts, Big Brothers/Big Sisters, Boys & Girls Club, and Estrella Family Services) and community leaders, East Side High School developed asset-building strategies and programs for students. Community groups and organizations around Santa Clara County partnered to build both the personal and financial resources needed to develop Project Cornerstone and maintain self-sufficiency.

Community groups had addressed many issues: (a) Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972, (b) the Federal Equal Access Act (EAA), (c) The No Child Left Behind (NCLB) Act, (d) equity in education, (e) ethnic groups, and (g) developmental assets. Most of the discussions focused on the need to help students at East Side High School and on identifying specific development programs to reduce student problems. Much of the discussion focused on basic approaches to implement Project Cornerstone.

East Side High School was well aware of Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972 and was fully compliant with the first comprehensive federal law prohibiting sex discrimination against students and employees of educational institutions (Deskbook 2006). Project Cornerstone also implemented nondiscrimination and equal access policies

to provide educational opportunities for all students and prohibited racial and sexual harassment on the part of staff and students. This practice complies with anti-discrimination laws that define and ensure equality in education. The policy is clearly stated in a charter school to ensure that all students in Project Cornerstone are allowed to participate without discrimination, exclusion, denial, limitation, or separation based on ethnic group or gender (Rebore, 2001, p. 207).

Project Cornerstone encouraged students to join a number of clubs and activities such as sports, chess, and other community service clubs. These activities were allowed to be organized at East Side High School with the principal's prior approval for developmental assets and related activities. This policy was compliant with the right to assemble under the Federal Equal Access Act (Deskbook 2006).

As a result of Project Cornerstone, a 2004 survey of nearly 14,000 4th- to 12th-grade students in schools regarding their experiences growing up in Santa Clara County provided administrators with a report card on how the community supports the healthy development of our youth and students. The survey showed that only 18% of middle and high school students had an average of 26 assets (out of 41 identified assets), and only 18% felt that the community values them. 26% of middle and high school students felt that they had opportunities for useful roles in the community, and 26% felt that they had positive role models in their lives. In addition, it showed academic performance increasing by 83 percentage points from 40%. Search Institute (1989) reported that the more assets students have, the more likely they are to grow up to be productive, competent, and responsible adults; they are less likely to engage in negative behaviors, such as alcohol abuse, threatening physical harm, drug abuse, and shoplifting. Research

also showed that the more assets students have, the more positive behaviors they exhibit, such as succeeding in school, helping others, maintaining good health, and bouncing back from adversity.

The school district invited a representative from Project Cornerstone to speak to the board and school principals and administrators. The principal, John Smith, partnered with Project Cornerstone to train and mobilize school staff, parents, and students to build assets that support students' academic and other areas of their lives. Workshops and seminars were developed to educate students and parents. The "Expect Respect/Leadership Challenge" workshop resulted in students/staff developing action plans to prevent bullying and create a safe, caring school climate. Training for teachers and staff on developmental assets will equip them to serve as leaders and role models in preventing bullying and promoting safe, caring school climates through their interactions with students on the school campus. Workshops for parents on these topics will reinforce the efforts of students and school staff to promote positive behavior. Special workshops for Spanish-speaking parents were also administered.

The principal, John Smith, assigned each departmental head to create monthly activities in music, art, science, or athletics, either during school hours or in the community. Each teacher was encouraged to sponsor a book club that meets bi-monthly. John also invited nursing home administrators, community center directors, and representatives from local hospitals and churches to speak to students about student volunteering programs. The department leaders also set up tutoring clubs, which were run by academically proficient students to help their struggling peers. Students who participated in these activities were given extra credit from their homeroom teachers.

Conclusion

Project Cornerstone is a catalyst for change. It is a collaborative effort by the entire community to build positive relationships, opportunities, values, and skills that students need to grow up caring and responsible. I think that developmental assets are far more valuable. It is the best investment that we can make for our young people and our entire community.

The challenge of Project Cornerstone is getting people to work together. A successful leader in this situation needs to demonstrate leadership in both the community and the school. They are essential partners in creating a positive environment by focusing on youth's strengths and providing constructive ways for them to meet the four critical elements—Belonging, Mastery, Independence, and Generosity. Belonging: Students need a caring, supportive relationship in their lives. Mastery: Students rely on the joy they receive from interests, hobbies, and group participation to balance disappointments in other parts of their lives. Independence: Students develop skills and confidence for leadership and self-discipline. Generosity: Students recognize responsibility for the welfare of others, which helps them focus on developing concern for others and taking action to demonstrate that concern (Rebore, 2001, p. 228).

I believe that our future education can make important contributions by teasing out more information about these causal relationships and helping answer the critical questions about assets' contribution to educational equity. There is strong evidence that positive relationships help develop assets and achievement. Although the weight of the research literature suggests that assets do, in fact, contribute to achievement, we do not

know much about the causal path or how it occurs. Much more research is still needed in this area.

On the issue of equity in education, I think it is complex and multifaceted. Many factors must be taken into account when planning for equity, including students, schools, community groups, compliance with local and federal laws, and finances.

In presenting this case study, it was not my intention to come across as an expert. While I believe that these reflections apply to me, I cannot say with any certainty that they will generalize to others. Where I do feel on solid ground is in putting forth these considerations. The first is that my personal ethical construct provides a framework for how I approach this problem. The second is the IRB requirement to conduct student surveys as part of research. This is a very significant part of the student survey, in which school staff and volunteers, as investigators, will be involved in data collection and in identifying students' developmental areas, and they will have an opportunity to explain the student survey, the risks, and alternative procedures. For example, investigators will engage with students and have conversations. Furthermore, all volunteers in Project Cornerstone will be fingerprinted and may be required to submit background checks, as are all adults who work in schools, to ensure they are safe to work in schools. This process is also important to me as I work toward a dissertation topic in collaborative learning. The final point is that school staff and volunteers are leaders. It is the responsibility of leaders to be fair, reasonable, and equitable. In addition, they need to be honest, open to communication, promise-keepers, fair sharers of benefits, respectful, and reciprocal.

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